Giuseppe Musillo

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Education

2022 to present	Ph.D. in Economics, Tilburg University Advisors: Prof. David Schindler, Prof. Mery Ferrando, Prof. Anna Salomons Expected Completion: June 2027
2020–2022	Research Master in Economics, Tilburg University
2019–2020	M.Sc. in Economics, Tilburg University
2016–2019	B.Sc. in International Economics and Finance, Bocconi University

Research Interests

Labor Economics, Political Economy, Economic History

Research Visits

Fall 2025	Universitat Pompeu Fabra (Host: Prof. Marta Reynal-Querol)
Spring 2024	LMU Munich (Host: Prof. Davide Cantoni)

Job Market Paper

Expertise-Leveling Technology and the Division of Creative Labor

Best Paper Award, 14th Warwick Economics PhD Conference; Best Paper Award, 19th Workshop on Social Economy for Young Economists

How does production adjust when technology lowers the expertise required to perform some tasks? I study digital sampling, which makes recorded performances reusable and reduces the expertise required for music production. I assemble novel data on production credits, sampling, artists' musical training, and content for 70,999 US records released between 1980 and 2000. A difference-in-differences design exploits geographic exposure to a new sampler's 1988 promotional campaign alongside Michael Jackson's tour. Campaign exposure increased sampling, with no detectable change in employment. Teams gained 0.45 musicians working exclusively in writing, composition, arrangement, and production, roughly 13 percent of the pre-period mean, without detectable broadening of individual task bundles. Artists associated with sampling were more likely to be self-taught and less likely to report formal musical training. Records became acoustically more differentiated from the previous year's releases, consistent with greater innovation in recorded sound. Lyrical differentiation showed no detectable change. The findings show that technology can change both the organization of production and innovation in output without a detectable employment response.

Publications

Labor Market Signals: The Role of Large Language Models (w/ K. Abbas Nejad, T. Wicker & N. Zaccaria), Journal of Labor Economics*, forthcoming, doi:10.1086/744669*

Large Language Models (LLMs) are transforming the labor market, including hiring decisions. This paper examines their impact on the signals job-seekers send to potential employers through two field experiments focusing on

cover letters. We find that LLMs enhance signal quality, especially benefiting lower-quality applicants, yet these gains do not boost interview invitations because they are concentrated in standardized, less influential sections of the cover letter. When recruiters learn of LLM usage, they place greater value on high-quality, human-crafted letters. Hence, LLMs reduce the informativeness of signals, potentially increasing inefficiencies in labor market matching as estimated by a calibrated structural model.

Working Papers

The Political Legacy of Fiction (w/ A. Armand, P. Atwell, J. F. Gomes & Y. Schenk, submitted)

We examine whether childhood exposure to fictional stories can shape long-run political preferences. We study an unprecedented experiment in post–WWII United States: in 1946, amid entrenched racial divisions, the popular children's radio series *The Adventures of Superman* suddenly replaced its fantasy plots with stories confronting intolerance in American society, explicitly designed to shape moral values among young listeners. This within-program shift generated variation in potential exposure across cohorts and locations, allowing us to isolate the causal effect of changing narrative content during childhood on later outcomes. We find that childhood exposure increased support for civil rights decades later, in the 1960s and 1970s, when racial equality was a contested dimension of American politics. These effects extend to support for civil rights leaders, political engagement, and lower institutional trust. At the county level, greater exposure increased political mobilization. Fictional narratives can therefore be a lasting channel of political socialization.

Work in Progress

State Repression, Trust, and Political Participation (w/ F. Capozza & M. Giugovaz)

How does violent state repression affect political participation in a mature democracy? We study the 2001 G8 summit in Genova, Italy, where police attacked authorized protests and committed abuses that courts later ruled met the international definition of torture. We measure each municipality's exposure by its proximity to the associations that organized travel to Genova. Exposure lowers turnout in national elections by 0.62 percentage points per standard deviation. The gradient is still visible in 2022, two decades after the summit. The effect is withdrawal, not realignment: it raises abstention among former voters, first on the left, and does not show up in petitions, demonstrations, or local and European elections. Two patterns point to a repression narrative that spread by word of mouth against a competing official account. The decline reaches one percentage point in rural municipalities and persists through 2013, while the urban effect fades to zero, and it shrinks where the reception of the mainstream television signal was stronger. Trust falls for the central institutions of the national state, and rises for interpersonal trust and local belonging. Repression cut the tie between citizens and the state, not the ties among citizens.

AI at the Gate: Platform Answers and the Supply of News (w/ T. Wicker & N. Zaccaria)

How does generative AI reshape competition and production in markets for information? We study this question through Google's AI Overviews, which place generated answers above search results. We combine the US and UK launches with a pre-launch measure of content replaceability: the share of an outlet's articles containing neither original reporting nor a distinctive authorial voice. The measure is constructed from 31,232 archived articles. In a weekly panel of 67 outlets, a one-standard-deviation increase in replaceability is associated with a 10.8% larger decline in visits after launch and an 8.7% decline in monthly unique visitors. The traffic gap widens over the following two years, although pre-launch trends and concurrent changes in search limit attribution. Headline-based searches show that more replaceable outlets are less likely to be cited by AI Overviews, despite similar content overlap. We find no detectable differential adjustment in article output or content composition. A dynamic model illustrates how an improvement in an AI alternative can reduce demand and firm values across incumbents while imposing larger losses on less differentiated outlets. The findings point to content differentiation and platform attribution as distinct influences on the distribution of losses from generative search.

Other Writings

AI maakt solliciteren makkelijker, maar matching moeilijker, ESB (2026), Vol. 111(4859): 330–332.

Teaching Experience

2024–present	Tutorial *Public Sector for Economics*, undergraduate level, Tilburg University
2022–present	Tutorial *Econometrics*, undergraduate level, Tilburg University
2022–2023	Tutorial *Microeconomics: Markets and Games*, undergraduate level, Tilburg University
2022–2023	Tutorial *Skills: Visualizing Data & Writing for Policy Makers*, undergraduate level, Tilburg University
2022–present	B.Sc. Thesis Supervision, Tilburg University (6 theses supervised)

Grants, Scholarships, and Awards

2026	MeToD grant, €11,700, for *State Repression, Trust, and Political Participation*
2026	Best Paper Award, 14th Warwick Economics PhD Conference, for *Expertise-Leveling Technology and the Division of Creative Labor* (Job Market Paper)
2026	Best Paper Award, 19th Workshop on Social Economy for Young Economists, for *Expertise-Leveling Technology and the Division of Creative Labor* (Job Market Paper)
2026	Departmental nomination, European Economic Association Award for Exceptional Teaching (junior category), Tilburg University
2024	OpenAI Researcher Access Program (Co-PI), $2,000
2023	Jenny Ligthart Award, CentER, best Research Master thesis

Research Assistance

2022	Research Assistant, TiSEM (Prof. David Schindler): digitized historical documents from the U.S. National Archive
2021	Research Assistant, TiSEM (Prof. David Schindler): assisted in designing and running a laboratory experiment

Seminar & Conference Presentations

2026	UPF Student Seminar, Applied Micro Meeting (Tilburg), AYEW Labor Economics Workshop, Applied Lunch (UPF), Internal Workshop (Tilburg), 4th Milan PhD Economics Workshop (Bocconi), 11th Monash-Paris-Warwick-Zurich-CEPR Text-As-Data Workshop, 19th Workshop on Social Economy for Young Economists (Bologna), 14th Warwick PhD Conference, 2nd EUI PhD Conference, ENTER Jamboree (UC3M), Venice Summer Institute, BID Workshop (TSE)
2025	Internal Workshop (Tilburg), 18th Workshop on Social Economy for Young Economists (Bologna), ENTER Jamboree (SSE), Applied Micro Chat (Tilburg), Public Governance Workshop (Université Paris Dauphine), Internal Seminar (UC3M)
2024	Empirical Student Seminar (LMU), Media Bias Workshop (Cologne), ENTER Jamboree (ULB), mEETing (Tilburg), Applied Micro Chat (Tilburg), MPE Brown-bag Research Seminar (Maastricht), Economic Insights for Creating Inclusive Labor Markets (University of Tokyo)
2023	Spanish Economic Association (Salamanca), Applied Seminar (Universitat Autonoma de Barcelona), Internal Workshop (Tilburg), Inaugural Essex PhD Conference in Applied Economics (Essex)

Academic Service

2023–present	Applied Micro Meeting Organizer, Tilburg University
2022–2025	ENTER Seminar Series Coordinator, Tilburg University
2021–2025	GSS Seminar Coordinator, Tilburg University
2021–2022	Education Committee Member, TiSEM, Tilburg University

Computer Skills

Python, R, Stata, ArcGIS.

Languages

Italian (native), English (fluent)

References

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